WHAT IF?! EP 07

FREE TIER LIST
you commented HIC

The Hiccup Cure Tier List



Every remedy our sources mention, ranked by evidence. Spoiler: the top tier is empty, and the best-published cure is not one you try at home.

S

Proven in controlled trials (randomised, big, boring)

Empty. We found no controlled trial of a hiccup cure in our sources. Sorry.

A

Published results, with an asterisk

The suction-and-swallow straw (FISST, sold as HiccAway). A 2021 JAMA Network Open study found about 92% of users said it stopped their hiccups. But there was no control group, it was self-reported, and the lead author invented the device.

B

Case report, one patient (do NOT try this at home)

The famous finger. A 1990 report (the second ever) described a 60-year-old man whose endless hiccups, after a nasogastric tube, stopped when a doctor performed digital rectal massage. They stopped abruptly, returned hours later, and stopped again. The idea is vagus-nerve stimulation. A doctor's procedure, not DIY advice.

C

Folk wisdom (no evidence found in our sources)



Hold your breath. A spoon of sugar. A good scare. The classic home cures. Some work for some people, but we cannot rank them higher on evidence.

Gargle. Sneeze. In Plato's Symposium, a doctor prescribes holding your breath, gargling or sneezing for hiccups. That would make these about 2,400 years old. (Our sources list this reference as unverified.)

D

The waiting game

Do nothing. Jennifer Mee's hiccups in 2007 (about 50 a minute) lasted about five weeks and then stopped. Charles Osborne's stopped by themselves after 68 years. Not a plan, but it is what happened.

F

Did nothing for Charles Osborne



Over 4,000 letters of home cures reportedly arrived at his door. None worked. (The number comes from secondary sources, so read it as "reportedly".)

Sources Guinness World Records (longest attack of hiccups) · Odeh, Bassan, Oliven, J Intern Med 1990;227:145-6 (pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/2299306) · JAMA Netw Open 2021 (PMC8214157) · CBS News, Mail & Guardian 2007 (Mee) · todayifoundout.com/?p=455

When to see a doctor

Most hiccups are harmless. Here is where the line is.



SEE A DOCTOR IF hiccups last **more than 48 hours** (doctors call that persistent; over a month is intractable), or they stop you eating, drinking or sleeping, or they started soon after surgery or a new medication. Long-lasting hiccups can have causes that need treating, including surgery, medications, tumours and brain lesions. A doctor can look for the cause.

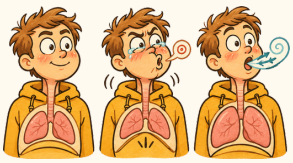
48 h
persistent: time to get it checked

1 month
intractable: a long-term problem

91% men
of intractable cases in one review, mostly over 50

WHAT A HICCUP ACTUALLY IS

Your diaphragm, the big muscle under your lungs, suddenly contracts. You gulp air, and your vocal cords snap shut. *Hic.* That snap is the noise. You have done this since before you were born: babies hiccup in the womb from about 9 weeks, and a 2019 UCL study suggests newborn hiccups may help the brain learn to regulate breathing. One theory says it is an echo of how amphibian gills worked.



THE 68-YEAR HICCUP



Charles Osborne of Iowa started hiccuping in 1922 while hanging a hog for butchering. Up to about 40 a minute at first, an estimated 430 million in total. Two marriages, eight children, a spot on TV.



They stopped on their own in 1990, with no cure and no reason, about a year before he died. Long attacks can also wear you down: lost sleep, weight loss and trouble eating.

HOW I RANKED THEM

Higher tier = better evidence, not "works for sure". Controlled trial beats published results, which beat a single case report, which beats folk wisdom, which beats a rumour. And no hiccup remedy here is proven to work better than waiting.

THE 430 MILLION MATHS

MATHS

430 million hiccups over 68 years is only about 12 a minute on average. So the early rate of up to 40 a minute must have dropped a lot, closer to about 20 later.



Sources Mayo Clinic (persistent vs intractable); NORD rare diseases (chronic hiccups) · PMC11862454 (intractable hiccups in men) · Scientific American (what causes hiccups) · UCL news Nov 2019 · Straus et al., BioEssays 2003 · Guinness World Records